able to consolidate a strategic inroad into India's neighbourhood in Central and South Asia in a less contested fashion than before. China's economic cooperation, aid, and support to countries in India's neigh-bourhood certainly resemble those of both proxy balancing and public-goods substitution aimed at reducing India's influence. Nonetheless, with China's power growing, there is a fine line between countering India's influence versus China becoming more concerned with consolidating its own influence in South Asia and the Indian Ocean Region. If the latter is dominating Chinese thinking, this is a subtle, yet important, shift in Chinese strategy and policy.[119]

What, then, about binding and wedge strategies to avoid India drifting into the orbit of the United States? The 2013 version of the Chinese Science of Military Strategy identified the United States carrying out strategic encirclement as the number-one challenge to China's peaceful development,[120] but this concern is now more targeted towards the larger Indo-Pacific region and less so with regard to China's immediate neighbourhood. In 2017, US President Trump laid out America's vision for the Indo-Pacific, confirming that the United States also has an eye on this expanded theatre.[121] The United States, India, Japan, and Australia have developed a Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) as a response to China's increased influence in the region.[122] The Quad receives criticism in China as an encirclement strategy.[123] With Japan and Australia as long-term alliance partners of the United States, it is India's growing partnership with Japan and in particular New Delhi's budding strategic relationship with Washington that have caught China's attention.[124] The Quad does not resemble an alliance, at least not yet, but it confirms the Indo-Pacific as an enlarged strategic theatre in which China and India both are major players.